Resistance

Resistance to the occupying forces started almost immediately. It often began with demonstrations calling for jobs or basic services like water and electricity. When things got out of control, US forces fired on the crowds. Then, when the Americans set up a temporary government, the **Coalition Provisional Authority** (CPA), they decided to abolish Saddam's army: suddenly, 350,000 soldiers were demobilised. They lost their salaries but kept their guns. Many joined the resistance. From 2004 onwards, the number of attacks on US forces increased. There were reckoned to be about 20,000–50,000 actively involved in the **insurgency**, as the armed resistance to the American occupation came to be known. There were many different groups involved, about 10 per cent of whom were thought to be non-Iraqi, some linked to al-Qaida.

Key terms

Coalition Provisional Authority
An organisation set up by the USA and its coalition allies to govern Iraq.

Insurgency
An uprising to try and overthrow a government.

Very few American forces spoke Arabic and they knew little of the customs of Iraq. Uncertain of who was friend and who was foe, the Americans struggled to restore law and order, let alone relieve the daily suffering of millions of Iraqis. As they rounded up hundreds, and then thousands, of suspects, they reopened the hated Abu Ghraib prison where so many Iraqis had been imprisoned and tortured under Saddam. Then, in 2004, it emerged that Americans themselves had been subjecting the inmates to their own form of humiliation and torture. A small number of American troops had taken photographs of the treatment of Iraqi prisoners: the worst of these showed naked prisoners forced to perform sex acts with each other or having electric cables attached to their arms, legs and genitals. Another showed a naked Iraqi prisoner, with a leash tied round his neck, being pulled along, like a dog, by a female American soldier. Only a few of the US troops were guilty but the publicity, both in Iraq and around the world, fuelled the resistance and did great damage to America's reputation.

Reconstructing Iraq

Key question
What were the difficulties of reconstruction?

Most of the members of the American-led CPA had little experience of rebuilding a national economy, let alone rebuilding a whole nation. However, their overriding concern was with dealing with the insurgency. While they concentrated on defeating the insurgency, the rebuilding of Iraq (e.g. repairing water, sewage and electricity systems) was neglected. Yet only when they were seen to be rebuilding the country and restoring essential services would they win the popular support needed to defeat the insurgents. It was a vicious circle and the insurgents knew it: they deliberately bombed water, sewage and electricity facilities, as well as US troops, in order to make the occupation unworkable.

Meanwhile, the US forces began to build and train a new Iraqi army and a police force but the new recruits became targets for the insurgents. At least 3000 Iraqi soldiers or police officers were killed by suicide bombers between 2003 and 2008. Anyone who